Hooway for Wodney Wat

By Helen Lester

INTRODUCTION

Do kids have to "fit in" by dressing, acting and thinking like everyone else. Let's hear a resounding NO! Hooway for Wodney Wat by Helen Lester explores the fear we all have about being different and encourages us to embrace our differences as advantages. Or as Rodney Rat would say "embwace or diffewences". Hooway for Wodeny Wat by Helen Letser.

Poor Wodney.

Wodney Wat.

His real name was Rodney Rat, but he couldn't pronounce his r's. To make matters worse, he was a rodent. A wodent.

"What's your name, Wodney?" asked the other rodents.

"Wodney Wat," whispered Wodney.

"What's another name for bunny?" they asked knowingly.

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" Wabbit," he mumbled.

"And how does a train travel?" They winked at each other.

"A twain twavels on twain twacks," WOdney replied miserably.

All of this teasing day in and day out made Wodney the shyest rodent in his elementary school. His squeak could barely be heard in class. He gnawed lunch alone. And while the other rodents scurried and scooted about at recess, Wodney hid inside his jacket.

Then one day as the rodents were taking turns doing wheelies, a new rodent – a very large rodent – barged into the classroom and announced:

"My name is Camilla Capybara. I'm bigger than any of you. I'm meaner than any of you and I'm smarter than any of you." Then she added, "So there."

With that she accidentally-on-purpose elbowed an ear, bumped two noses, stepped on three tails, and lay down on a desk. Fur prickled in fear through the classroom. She sure was bigger than any of them. She

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sure looked meaner than any of them. Was she smarter than any of them?

"What's 2 + 2?" asked Miss Fuzzleworth

"FOUR!" shouted Camilla Capybara without even bothering to raise her paw. "And furthermore, 4+4 is 8, 8+8 is 6 and 243 + 125 is 368."

Later, when Miss Fuzzleworth asked, "What's the capital of . . . . "

Camilla interrupted, "New York, Albany, Population 295,594."

And during science, in answer to the question, "What part of a plant is blow the ground?" Camilla Capybara danced on her desk and sang, "Root! Root! Rooty-toot-toot!"

"Yup!" thought all the other rodents. "She's smarter than we are, too." They felt very, very uncomfortable.

Every afternoon, just before the final recess, Miss Fuzzleworth drew a name from her hat to see who would be the leader for their favorite game, Simon Says. She scrunched her eyes closed and jiggled the hat.

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Would it be Hairy Hamster? Minifeet Mouse? Grizzlefriz Guinea Pig? Could it be big, mean, smart Camilla Capybara? Miss Fuzzleworth's paw reached in and pulled out the name of . . . Wodney Wat!

The bell rang, there was a wild scurry for the door, and Camilla Capybara was the first on the playground, having trampled the others in her path. To Wodney she looked especially scary. What would she do when she heard him speak? Breathe capybara breath in his face? Or tie him up in his own tail? Or even POUNCE on him?

The tiny, trembling leader of the game stood before the eager players, his head well inside his jacket, and squeaked.

"Wodney says weed the sign"

While the other rodents read, "P.S. 142 ELEMENTARY SCHOOL FOR RODENTS," Camilla began pulling up weeks around the sign and wildly flinging them hither and yon till she was clear up to her teeth in dirt.

The other rodents began to smile.

"Wodney says wap your paws awound your head."

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He peeked a little peek out of his jacket and saw WHAP! WHAP! WHAPPITY SLAPPITY WHAP! Camilla was whapping her paws around her head so hard she became dizzy, gave herself a headache, and had to sit down. The other rodents couldn't help giggling.

"Wodney says play Wing Awound the Wosey."

Camilla put out her arms like wings and made an airplane noise, "Nnnnrrrr." But where was the wosey? WHAT was a wosey?

By now Wodney's voice was stronger and his head was entirely out of his jacket.

"Wake the leaves!"

Nobody moved.

"Wodney says wake the leaves.

While Hairy, Minifeet, and Grizzlefriz and the others busied themselves raking, Camilla Capybara grabbed one leaf. "Wake up!" she yelled

She snatched another, "Come on, you. Up, up, up!" And another, "Rise and shine!" And another, "BOO!"

By now all the other rodents were squealing with laughter. All but Camilla, who frowned. "Stupid leaves.

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They won't wake up!" And why was everyone laughing at her? Such bullies!

In a voice so strong he had to hold his own ears, Wodney called, "Wodney says go west!"

The rodents collapsed in a happy heap for a rest *Go west.*

Camilla Capybara, feeling very smart that she could tell directions by the sun, said, "All right. I shall go west." And then she added, "So there."

West she stomped. Forever. She was gone . . . And from that day on the pupils of PS 142 Elementary School for Rodents never teased Wodney again. He was their hero.

"Hooway for Wodney Wat! they cried. Whoot! Whoot! Wooty-toot-toot!

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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